



WEEK SIX · MODULE TWO

How This World Really Hires

The confidential note on agencies, references, and the conversation you will never hear

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

Maison Amarine · Confidential · For the use of our mentees only

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HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

This is the note that would have saved me a year, and nobody writes it down, because the people who know it have no incentive to explain it.

Some of it is unflattering to this industry. All of it is accurate.

Read it before you write a single letter.

CHAPTER I

What a consultant actually sees

Eight seconds, and what happens in them

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand how your application is really read.

Write for the reader who exists rather than the one you imagine.

You imagine a consultant reading your letter carefully, weighing your experience, considering your potential.

What actually happens is this. She has forty-one unread applications, eleven live roles, a family in Monaco who wants a decision today, and a candidate who has just withdrawn from a placement she has been working on for three weeks. Your letter is opened at 18:40 and it gets **eight seconds**.

In those eight seconds she is answering three questions, in this order, and nothing else:

- **Is this person placeable at all?** Meaning: is there any role, out of my eleven, that a family would take them for. If no, she stops here, and it is not a judgement of you, it is a judgement of the eleven.
- **Would I be embarrassed to put them in front of a family?** This is the question that kills. Presentation, spelling, tone, inflation, a photograph that was a mistake, an email address from 2009. It is not fair and it is not going to change.
- **Do I already know this person?** If yes, the previous two questions are answered much more generously. That is the entire reason for this week.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR YOUR LETTER

It is not read. It is scanned, at speed, by someone tired, for reasons to stop.

So: no paragraph over four lines. The rung you are on, stated in the first sentence. No inflation, because inflation is the fastest way to be dismissed by someone who has seen ten thousand CVs. And nothing, anywhere, that would make her hesitate to attach your name to hers.

CHAPTER II

Why they never reply

And why it is not what you think

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Stop interpreting silence.

Understand the arithmetic that produces it.

You will write to agencies and you will hear nothing. Not a rejection. Nothing at all. And you will decide, because everybody decides this, that you are not good enough, or that this world is closed to people like you.

Here is what is actually happening. **A consultant is not paid to reply to you.** She is paid when a family signs. Every hour spent replying to candidates she cannot currently place is an hour not spent on the eleven roles that will feed her family this quarter.

It is not rudeness, though it feels exactly like rudeness. It is arithmetic, and it is the same arithmetic in every agency in every city, and no amount of hurt on your part changes it.

2.1 · So what actually works

Instead of

Do this

Following up in a week, anxiously.

Nothing at all for ninety days. Silence is not a door closing. It is a door that has not opened yet.

"Just checking in."

A follow-up that contains something new and real: a season worked, a language reached, a course completed, a reference gained. You are not asking. You are updating a file that she is keeping.

Writing to the general inbox.

Writing to a named consultant, about the market she actually covers, having done the research. Ninety per cent of candidates cannot be bothered to do this, and she knows it.

Applying to a role.

Asking to be registered, and saying, in one line, that you are not expecting anything immediately. She has not heard that sentence in a year.

CHAPTER III

The reference economy

The currency of this entire profession

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand that you are building references from your first day, forever.

Handle the reference you cannot use.

In most industries a reference is a formality. In this one it is the product.

A family is about to give a stranger the keys to their home, their movements and their children. There is no qualification on earth that answers that. **The only thing that answers it is another person, whom they trust, saying that you are safe.**

3.1 · What this changes about your entire career

- Every house is a reference, including the bad one. Especially the bad one, because the way you left it is what will be described.
- Every colleague is a reference. The housekeeper you were short with in a difficult week will be somewhere else in five years, and someone will ask her.
- Every supplier is a reference. The florist knows six households. When one of them asks whether he knows anyone, he does.
- Two years is the unit. A CV of eight-month positions, however good the reasons, reads as a person who does not last, and there is no explaining your way out of it in eight seconds.

3.2 · The reference you cannot use

You will very likely have a house you cannot name. An NDA that forbids it. A family whose identity is not yours to give. This is normal at the top of this profession, and it is not the obstacle you think it is, and here is how it is handled.

THE FORMULATION

"I worked for a private family in [city or region], for [duration], with responsibility for [functions]. I am bound by a confidentiality agreement and I am not able to give their name. My reference for that period is available through [the family office, the agency, a named senior colleague who is permitted to speak]."

Then you stop. You do not hint. You do not smile as though you might say more. You do not offer a clue about who it was.

And understand what has just happened in the room. You have said, without saying it, that you were trusted by a family who required an NDA, and that you are still keeping it, in the room, to your own commercial disadvantage.

For the right employer, that is not a gap in your file. That is the single most persuasive thing you could possibly have done. The wrong employer will push. That is information too, and it is free.

CHAPTER IV

The room you are not in

What is actually asked about you

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Understand the question that decides your hire.

Somewhere, a principal turns to someone he trusts, and he asks about you. It lasts ninety seconds. It is not recorded, you will never know it happened, and it is worth more than your entire application.

And here is what is asked. Not "is she good at the job". They assume that, or you would not have reached this room.

The question	What it is really testing
"What is she like?"	Whether you are pleasant to have in a house every day for four years. An enormous number of technically excellent people fail here.
"Would you have her back?"	The only reference question that matters. Any hesitation, of even half a second, is the answer.
"Does she talk?"	The Week 3 question, and it is asked about you by people who have never met you, on the basis of what they have heard.
"Is she solid?"	Meaning: will she still be here in three years. Meaning: is she dramatic, is she fragile, does she create weather.

WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY BUILDING, ALL THE TIME

You are building the answer to a question you will never hear, asked by a person you have never met, to somebody who worked beside you five years ago.

That is the whole market. Everything else is paperwork.

CHAPTER V

The years nobody warns you about

The honest version of the timeline

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Have a realistic expectation of the first three years.

Understand why most people leave, and it is not the work.

I would rather you were disappointed by this page than by your first eighteen months.

Period	What it is actually like
Months 0 to 6	You are applying and hearing very little. This is the phase where most people conclude that the market is closed and stop. It is not closed. You are simply not yet in anybody's folder, and you have not yet been vouched for by anyone, and both of those take exactly this long.
The first role	Very often not the one you wanted. Frequently a season, a villa, a chalet, a maternity cover, a temporary role over a holiday. Take it, and be flawless in it. Every single person in this profession has one of these at the bottom of their CV and none of them mention it.
Years 1 to 2	You are learning that you knew nothing, which is uncomfortable and entirely normal. Your value here is not your competence. It is your reliability and your discretion, and they are being measured every day.
Year 2	The turn. Somebody says your name in a room. You will not know it happened. But the second role is easier than the first by an order of magnitude, and the third is offered to you without your applying at all.
Years 5 to 10	You are now inside the referral market, which means you have stopped applying for work, and work has begun to be brought to you. This is the entire objective, and it is reached by exactly one route, which is the boring one.

And the reason people leave is almost never the work, and almost never the money. It is the first six months of silence. They are talented, and they are ready, and nobody answers, and they conclude that it was not for them. It was for them. They stopped four months too early.

CHAPTER VI

Case law

*Six ways in***LEARNING OBJECTIVES**

Recognise how doors actually open.

The chalet season

A woman from luxury hotels, thirty-one, no household experience at all, two hundred applications sent over eight months, four replies, none of them good.

She took a chalet season in Verbier. Guest relations, four months, a fraction of the salary she wanted, and by any measure a step backwards from the hotel she had left.

In February she looked after a family for eleven days. In March the wife wrote to her directly. She has now been their private concierge for six years.

She did not get that role by applying. She got it by being in a room with the right family, doing an ordinary job flawlessly. This is the most common route into this profession and almost nobody plans it deliberately.

The florist

A man in London, unable to get past a single agency, was introduced to a florist who worked for four private households, and, having nothing else to do with his afternoon, was useful to him. He sent him a supplier. He recommended him to a hotel. He asked for nothing, for a year.

When one of the four households lost its house manager, the florist was asked, over the flowers, on a Tuesday, whether he knew anyone.

The people who hear about roles first are not the agencies. They are the suppliers. They are entirely reachable, nobody ever writes to them, and they are usually delighted to be asked.

The letter that was answered

Two hundred candidates wrote to a senior estate manager in Geneva that year. She answered one.

It began with an accurate, specific line about a talk the estate manager had given, which the writer had clearly attended rather than merely found. It stated, in one sentence and without inflation, exactly what the writer was and what rung she was on. It contained a supplier recommendation, in Geneva, that was genuinely useful.

It asked for nothing at all, and it ended: "if it is not a good moment, please ignore this entirely."

The estate manager replied in four lines. Three months later the writer sent something else useful, again with no ask. Nine months later she was recommended for a role that was never advertised. **The whole thing took under a year and cost her nothing except patience.**

The one who inflated

A capable woman with four years in a serious hotel described herself, on her CV, as having "managed a UHNW household portfolio". It was a stretch of something that was partly true. Everybody does it, and she thought nothing of it.

The consultant, who had placed two hundred people, asked one gentle follow-up question in the interview. It took eleven seconds to establish what had actually happened.

She was not confronted, and she was not accused. She was simply never presented for anything again, by that agency, and by any consultant who moved from that agency to another one. **Her actual four years in a hotel would have been perfectly respectable, and would have got her a first rung.** The inflation cost her the market.

The reference she could not give

A candidate, in a final interview, was asked directly for the name of the family she had worked for. She said, calmly, that she was bound by a confidentiality agreement, that she was not able to give their name, that her reference for the period was available through the family office, and then she said nothing else, and she did not look away.

The principal pressed once. She repeated it, in the same words, without apology and without any change of expression.

She was offered the role that week. He said afterwards, to the agency, that it was the only moment in the interview that had told him anything. **He had not been testing her discretion by accident.**

The four hundred euros

An agency, glossy website, impressive photographs, extremely encouraging. They loved her profile. They had families waiting. There was simply a four hundred euro fee to be added to their priority list, entirely standard, refundable against her first placement.

She paid it. She was never contacted again, and the telephone number stopped working within the year.

A legitimate agency is paid by the family. It has never, in the history of this profession, been paid by the candidate. If you are asked for money to be represented, that is not an agency, and the sole product being sold is your hope.

Glossary

The eight seconds · How long your application is actually read, by someone tired, looking for a reason to stop.

The silence · The absence of reply. It is arithmetic, not judgement, and misreading it is why people leave the profession.

The ninety-day follow-up · A follow-up that contains something new and real. Never "just checking in".

The reference economy · This market's actual currency. Every house, every colleague, every supplier, forever.

The undisclosable house · A role you cannot name. Handled with one calm formulation and no hints, and it becomes your strongest asset.

"Would you have her back?" · The only reference question that matters. Hesitation is the answer.

The turn · Year two, when your name begins to be said in rooms you are not in.

Self-assessment

Answer in writing.

1. What are the three questions a consultant answers in eight seconds, and which one kills the most candidates?
2. Explain why an agency does not reply, without using the words rude, closed, or unfair.
3. Write a ninety-day follow-up message that contains something real. Then count the words. It should be under sixty.
4. Why is a reference the actual product in this market, and what is it really answering for the family?
5. You cannot name your former employer. Write out, word for word, what you say, and then describe exactly what you do in the four seconds afterwards.
6. What is the only reference question that matters, and why is hesitation the answer?
7. In the case of the inflated CV: her real experience was respectable. Explain precisely what the inflation cost her, and why it was disproportionate.
8. In the case of the chalet season: she took a step backwards and it worked. Explain why, structurally, and not sentimentally.
9. Why do most people leave this profession in the first six months, and what would you need to believe to survive that period?
10. You are asked for a fee to be represented. Write your reply, and then write what you owe to the next person.

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